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‘Irfan: A Journey into Islamic Mysticism

An Introduction for Seekers

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Book Two · Expanded edition

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Seeking, not powers

The verse is often recited at weddings. The families have gathered and the *nikah* is about to be read. Before it, someone reads the line from Surah al-Rum about the spouses God created for us, so “that you may take comfort in them”, and the “affection and mercy” He ordained between husband and wife (Q 30:21). Everyone in the room recognises it. It is beautiful, and it is true.

The verse does not stop at affection and mercy, though. It ends: “There are indeed signs in that for a people who reflect.” The sign is there for everyone at the wedding, but the verse says it is meant for a particular kind of person.

WORDS YOU’LL MEET *‘Irfan · ma‘rifah · ‘arif · muqarrabun · awliya’ Allah*

What the minimum leaves out

Start with what is not in dispute. A believer who prays the five daily prayers, fasts in Ramadan, pays what is due and performs the hajj is on a sound path. If he does what is *wajib*, what is obligatory, and keeps away from what is forbidden, he can hope for *janna*. Sheikh Bahmanpour, whose lectures this book is drawn from, says so plainly: following the *shari‘a*, the sacred law, and reaching Paradise by it is “fair enough” for ordinary believers. Some jurists and activists go further and say that this is the whole of religion, and that anything more was “made up by some mystics according to their vibes and wishes”.



Nothing in this chapter asks you to doubt the first claim. The floor is real, and it saves.

The second claim is the one to test, and the simplest test is the Quran. Here is the passage the wedding verse belongs to.

وَمِنْ آيَاتِهِ أَنْ خَلَقَ لَكُمْ مِنْ أَنْفُسِكُمْ أَزْوَاجًا لِتَسْكُنُوا إِلَيْهَا وَجَعَلَ بَيْنَكُمْ مَوَدَّةً وَرَحْمَةً إِنَّ فِي ذَلِكَ لَآيَاتٍ لِقَوْمٍ يَتَفَكَّرُونَ ﴿٢١﴾ وَمِنْ آيَاتِهِ خَلْقَ السَّمَوَاتِ وَالْأَرْضِ وَاخْتِلَافِ اللُّغَاتِ وَالْوَلَوَاتِ إِنَّ فِي ذَلِكَ لَآيَاتٍ لِّلْعَالَمِينَ ﴿٢٢﴾ وَمِنْ آيَاتِهِ مَنَامُكُمْ بِاللَّيْلِ وَالنَّهَارِ وَابْتِغَاؤُكُمْ مِنْ فَضْلِهِ إِنَّ فِي ذَلِكَ لَآيَاتٍ لِقَوْمٍ يُسْمِعُونَ ﴿٢٣﴾ وَمِنْ آيَاتِهِ يُرِيكُمُ الْبَرْقَ خَوْفًا وَطَمَعًا وَيُنْزِلُ مِنَ السَّمَاءِ مَاءً فَيُحْيِي بِهِ الْأَرْضَ بَعْدَ مَوْتِهَا إِنَّ فِي ذَلِكَ لَآيَاتٍ لِقَوْمٍ يَعْقِلُونَ ﴿٢٤﴾

And of His signs is that He created for you mates from your own selves that you may take comfort in them, and He ordained affection and mercy between you. There are indeed signs in that for a people who reflect.

Among His signs is the creation of the heavens and the earth, and the difference of your languages and colours. There are indeed signs in that for those who know.

And of His signs is your sleep by night and day, and your pursuit of His bounty. There are indeed signs in that for a people who listen.

And of His signs is that He shows you the lightning, arousing fear and hope, and He sends down water from the sky, and with it revives the earth after its death. There are indeed signs in that for people who exercise their reason.

Quran 30:21-24

The four verses point to marriage, the languages and colours of the people around us, sleep, earning a living, a storm, rain. None of it is exotic. It is the ordinary material of a Muslim's week, the same week in which he prays and fasts. Each verse then closes by naming a capacity: reflecting, knowing,



listening, reasoning. The Quran is not asking for a new set of duties. It is asking whether we perceive what is already in front of us.

That is the sense in which the Quran invites more than the minimum. The invitation is not to go around the law or above it. Imam Khomeini insists that a genuine seeker’s devotion “is within the bounds of the Shari’ah”¹. The invitation is to the inside of the life the law already shapes: to see, in the marriage and the sleep and the rain, the One whose signs they are.

Signs most people miss

The endings of those verses are restrictive. The signs are “for a people who reflect”, “for those who know”. Sheikh Bahmanpour draws the obvious conclusion: not for everyone. When we look at the variety of languages and colours, we are more likely to see a reason for division than a sign of God. And the lack is not only among the careless. Most pious people, he says, and even most of those who are scrupulous about the shari’a, do not find the sign in these things.

He admits that when he reads these verses he feels the Quran is reproaching us. It seems to say: you do not reflect, you do not know, you do not listen, you do not use your reason. The same charge returns elsewhere. God asks who but He could bring light if He made the night last until the Day of Resurrection, and the verse ends: “Will you not listen?” (Q 28:71). If we truly heard these signs, he says, we would be moved by them as the prophets and the friends of God are moved.

Most of us accept that the signs exist out of obedience. The Quran says there are signs, so there are signs. But accepting is not catching. One verse describes the whole situation.

وَكَايْنٍ مِّنْ ءَايَةٍ فِي السَّمٰوٰتِ وَٱلْأَرْضِ يَمُرُّونَ عَلَيْهَا وَهُمْ عَنْهَا مُعْرِضُونَ

﴿١٠٥﴾

*How many a sign there is in the heavens and the earth that they pass
by while they are disregarding of it!*

Quran 12:105

¹Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 61.



‘Allama Tabataba’i gives an image for what it would mean to catch a sign. A person who sees a red light thinks of the danger it warns of, not of the colour and shape of the lamp. In the same way, the things of the world are signs, and “what the signs indicate is not this world, but the person of its Creator”². Most of us look at the lamp. The rain is rain, the marriage is a marriage, and we pass by.

So the signs are present, they are plain, and they are addressed to us. If most people still miss them, the failure has to lie somewhere other than in the signs.

The fault is in the receiver

The Quran locates it. In a verse that is hard to hear, it speaks of people who have every faculty and use none of them.

وَلَقَدْ ذَرَأْنَا لِجَهَنَّمَ كَثِيرًا مِّنَ الْجِنِّ وَالْإِنسِ لَهُمْ قُلُوبٌ بَّ لَا يَفْقَهُونَ بِهَا
وَلَهُمْ أَعْيُنٌ لَا يُبْصِرُونَ بِهَا وَلَهُمْ أُذُنٌ لَا يَسْمَعُونَ بِهَا أُولَٰئِكَ
كَالْأَنْعَامِ بَلْ هُمْ أَضَلُّ أُولَٰئِكَ هُمُ الْغَافِلُونَ ﴿١٧٩﴾

Certainly We have winnowed out for hell many of the jinn and humans: they have hearts with which they do not understand, they have eyes with which they do not see, they have ears with which they do not hear. They are like cattle; indeed, they are more astray. It is they who are the heedless.

Quran 7:179

Cattle see and hear perfectly well, so the comparison cannot be about the senses. Sheikh Bahmanpour reads it as being about what lies behind them. Eyes and ears take in the surface of things. Inside a human being there is something that should translate what they take in into its reality: an inner faculty that animals lack and that we have. In most of us, he says, it is not working. A person who rejects faith may protest that he sees in more detail than any believer. The Quran’s answer is that he sees, but does not understand.

Sheikh Bahmanpour’s own image for this faculty is a machine. The ear catches the sound, but “there is something inside which doesn’t catch it. There is a machine inside which is rust.” That machine is the soul. It is broken;

²Mutahhari, Tabataba’i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, pp. 6–7.



it does not work; and it has to be repaired before it can catch the signals of God. This, for him, is the whole subject in one sentence: “Mysticism is all about making one’s soul to hear, to see and to reflect.” Everything else in this book, the stages, the disciplines and the dangers, is about how that repair is done. He does not pretend it is easy: “It needs lots of training.”

Two things follow from putting the fault here. The first is that the problem is not a shortage of evidence. God is not withholding signs from us; we are failing to receive them. The second is that the problem can be solved. A faculty that exists but is rusted is a different case from one that is absent. The *Kernel of the Kernels*, a record of ‘Allama Tabataba’i’s early lectures on the path, opens by saying that the pull towards the unseen is “part of the innate instincts of the human being”³. The longing, and the faculty it belongs to, are part of how we are made. What it needs is not replacement but repair.

And repair is only the start. Once the inner faculty begins to work, Sheikh Bahmanpour says, the real journey begins, and it does not end: the path “has a beginning and no end”. What a soul sees and hears after that, God alone knows.

Some do see

If the receiver can be repaired, there should be people in whom it works. The Quran describes them repeatedly. Sheikh Bahmanpour puts it simply: there are two groups of people, those whose souls work and those whose souls do not. The first he calls the *‘urafa’*, the plural of *‘arif*, “someone who knows”. He sets the prophets and Imams (‘a) aside as a class of their own, and asks about ordinary believers who see more than the rest.

The first description is in Surah al-Anfal.

إِنَّمَا الْمُؤْمِنُونَ الَّذِينَ إِذَا ذُكِرَ اللَّهُ وَجِلَتْ قُلُوبُهُمْ وَإِذَا تُلِيَتْ عَلَيْهِمْ آيَاتُهُ زَادَتْهُمْ إِيمَانًا وَعَلَىٰ رَبِّهِمْ يَتَوَكَّلُونَ ﴿٢﴾

The faithful are only those whose hearts tremble [with awe] when Allah is mentioned, and when His signs are recited to them, they increase their faith, and who put their trust in their Lord, ...

Quran 8:2

³‘Allama Tabataba’i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara’i), p. 4.



A heart only trembles at the mention of something it has some experience of. A name means little to someone who does not know whom it names. So the believers of this verse are believers who know Allah. The opening of Surah al-Mu'minun describes the same people at prayer: "those who are humble in their prayers" (Q 23:2). The word is *khashi'*, and it means more than humble. It describes someone in whom something gives way when they stand before God, because of what they have experienced of Him.

Higher still is a verse about God's oneness.

شَهِدَ اللَّهُ أَنَّهُ لَا إِلَهَ إِلَّا هُوَ وَالْمَلَائِكَةُ وَأُولُوا الْعِلْمِ قَائِمًا بِالْقِسْطِ لَا إِلَهَ إِلَّا هُوَ الْعَزِيزُ الْحَكِيمُ ﴿١٨﴾

Allah, maintainer of justice, the Almighty and the All-wise, besides whom there is no god, bears witness that there is no god except Him, and [so do] the angels and those who possess knowledge.

Quran 3:18

God witnesses His own oneness, the angels witness it, and so do "those who possess knowledge", *ulu al-'ilm*. Sheikh Bahmanpour reads this as another name for the 'urafa'. Every Muslim knows that there is no god but Allah. But our knowledge of *tawhid*, God's oneness, is not the knowledge of those who witness it. Tawhid is simple to say and very hard to grasp, and he holds that the intellect alone cannot reach its depths; only the awakened soul can.

Surah Fatir adds: "Only those of Allah's servants having knowledge fear Him" (Q 35:28). Most of us fear Allah's punishment. The people of this verse fear Him, with a fear that is not about punishment at all. And Surah Yunus gives them a second name, which the lectures treat as the same people: the *awliya'* Allah, the friends of God (Q 10:62).

What these people see that others miss, Imam 'Ali ('a) describes in a short saying about the friends of God, whom the lectures treat as the same people as the 'urafa'.

*God's special devotees are those who perceive the world's reality when others are deceived by her appearance. They occupy themselves with what is coming when others occupy themselves with the present.*⁴

⁴Imam 'Ali, *Nahj al-Balagha* (trans. Qutbuddin), 3.403.



Other people look at the surface of the world; the friends of God look at its inside. Sheikh Bahmanpour is careful about the reason. There is nothing wrong, in the shari‘a, with being rich. The trouble is being occupied with it. The friends of God have families, friends and a place in society, as we do. But they do not think about themselves; they think about God, and in their hearts they are cut off from everything else. These are the people for whom the signs of Surah al-Rum were written. The Quran does not describe them as a theory. It describes them as believers.

What they are given, and why it is open to you

The Quran does not only describe these people. It tells us what they receive, and whether the rest of us can join them.

The reward. The first gift is nearness. Surah al-Waqi‘a sorts people on the Last Day, and at the top it places “the Foremost Ones”, who “are the ones brought near [to Allah]” (Q 56:10–11). The word is *muqarrabun*. Sheikh Bahmanpour points out that God is not far from anyone. To be brought near means that a veil between the person and God has been removed, and so they understand far better. The second gift is a different kind of life.

مَنْ عَمِلَ صَالِحًا مِّنْ ذَكَرٍ أَوْ أُنْثَىٰ وَهُوَ مُؤْمِنٌ فَلَنُحْيِيَنَّهٗ حَيٰوةً طَيِّبَةً
وَلَنَجْزِيَنَّهُمْ أَجْرَهُم بِأَحْسَنِ مَا كَانُوا يَعْمَلُونَ ﴿٩٧﴾

Whoever acts righteously, [whether] male or female, should be be faithful, We shall revive him with a good life and pay them their reward by the best of what they used to do.

Quran 16:97

The “good life”, *hayat tayyiba*, is in the lecturer’s reading a clean life, pure of the filth of this world. Its people live in the world without living in its filth, and rise above the concerns that infect everyone else. This good life, he says, “is of course what mystics are after”. The third gift is peace.

أَلَا إِنَّ أَوْلِيَاءَ اللَّهِ لَا خَوْفٌ عَلَيْهِمْ وَلَا هُمْ يَحْزَنُونَ ﴿٦٢﴾

Look! The friends of Allah will indeed have no fear nor will they grieve

Quran 10:62



Put together, the promise is striking. For the muqarrabun, Sheikh Bahmanpour says, “the whole terms and conditions are different”. They are given Paradise in this world, and in the next they are after something more.

The access. None of this would matter to an ordinary reader if it were reserved for prophets. The lectures answer from Surah al-Nisa’.

وَمَنْ يُطِيعِ اللَّهَ وَالرَّسُولَ فَأُولَٰئِكَ مَعَ الَّذِينَ أَنْعَمَ اللَّهُ عَلَيْهِمْ مِنَ النَّبِيِّينَ
وَالصَّادِقِينَ وَالشُّهَدَاءِ وَالصَّالِحِينَ وَحَسُنَ أُولَٰئِكَ رَفِيقًا ﴿٦٩﴾

Whoever obeys Allah and the Apostle—they are with those whom Allah has blessed, including the prophets and the truthful, the martyrs and the righteous, and excellent companions are they!

Quran 4:69

Sheikh Bahmanpour reads this verse as naming four ranks of those God has blessed: the prophets; the truthful (*siddiqin*); the *shuhada’*, which the translation used here renders “martyrs” and the lectures take as “the witnesses”; and the righteous (*salihin*). The blessing is plainly not wealth or a strong body. The first three ranks, he says, are beyond us. The fourth is a doorway. The *salihin* are those with the capacity to receive this favour, and it is from among them that God chooses the truthful and the prophets. Righteous action, as the verse on the good life also says, is the way in.

So “ordinary people also can enter into the realm of muqarrabun”. It is very difficult, he says, but it is open. And he gives the reason it is open. We are made for it. He puts it bluntly: we call ourselves human beings, but “we are not yet human beings”. We begin with the potential to become human, as the prophets are fully human. The point is not to diminish us but to show what we were made for: “A human being has the capacity to become a friend of God. Allah has created us at this strength and He wants us to reach that strength.”

Hence. The earlier sections showed that the Quran invites more than the minimum, and that what stands in the way is a faculty in us that can be repaired. This section adds what lies on the other side: nearness to God, a good life, freedom from fear and grief, and a rank that the Quran opens to any believer who obeys God and the Prophet and acts righteously. That is worth pursuing.



For what? Not powers

Pursuing it means training the soul, and soul-training is not unique to Islam. Sheikh Bahmanpour opened his course by pointing out that people take up the inner life for very different reasons. Some train the soul to gain power: to be in two places at once, to see the future or the past, to explore the hidden world of the soul so that they can master it. That kind of mysticism, he says, must be told apart from the real thing, because Islamic mysticism is about something else: catching the signs of Allah: becoming sensitive to them, and learning to hear and see.

His closing words to his first class were stronger. ‘Irfan “is not about any type of power or empowering the soul” to work *karamat* and *mu’jizat*, the wonders of the saints and the miracles of the prophets. Then: “These are shirk.” *Shirk*, associating partners with God, is the gravest charge in Islam, and he does not soften it. [QUERY: L01 ¶32, "These are shirk": does "these" mean seeking *karamat* and *mu’jizat*, or the powers themselves? Confirm with the lecturer.]

The great teachers of the Shia tradition make closely related points, each in his own words. ‘Allama Tabataba’i tells the traveller that he “has no right to seek occult experiences and miraculous qualities”, nor to perform austerities or recite invocations to gain powers such as crossing great distances in a moment or reading the thoughts of others. Whoever does so “does not move on the path of the Beloved’s pleasure and his worship is not for the sake of God”. It is his own self that he worships, “though he may not admit it by word of mouth”⁵.

◆ WHO'S WHO: ‘ALLAMA TABATABA’I

Sayyid Muhammad Husayn Tabataba’i is best known as the author of *al-Mizan*, a commentary on the Quran in twenty volumes⁶. His student Sayyid Muhammad Husayn Husayni Tihirani describes him as having flown “with the two wings of knowledge and action”. He travelled the path in both philosophy and gnosis under the guidance of the gnostic Mirza ‘Ali Aqa Qadi, and after years of philosophical argument he “came to settle down at the sacred threshold of the Qur’an”⁷. *Kernel of the Kernels* (*Lubb al-Lubab*) is Tihirani’s record of the lectures

⁵‘Allama Tabataba’i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihirani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara’i), pp. 28–29.

⁶Mohammad Ali Shomali, *Self-Knowledge*, p. 30.

⁷‘Allama Tabataba’i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihirani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara’i), p. 8.

⁸‘Allama Tabataba’i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihirani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara’i), p. 9.



on ethics and gnosis that Tabataba'i gave to students in Qum in 1949–50⁸. He also wrote the preface to *Light Within Me*⁹, from which several quotations in this chapter come.

Imam Khomeini reports the test his teacher Ayatullah Shahabadi used: the measure of true spiritual effort is how much selfishness is in it. If a traveller's "spiritual exercises are meant for acquiring powers for worldly ends, his efforts are rendered invalid"¹⁰. Murtada Mutahhari uses the lecturer's own word. The 'urafa', he writes, consider it "a kind of shirk (polytheism) for one's goal in life and particularly in worship to be something other than God Himself". He recalls the words of Imam 'Ali ('a): "My God, I do not worship You in fear of Your Fire, nor in desire for Your Paradise, but I find You worthy of worship so I worship You"¹¹. If even Paradise is not to be the goal, powers certainly are not.

Sheikh Bahmanpour calls such powers shirk, and Mutahhari's words show why seeking them would be: the goal has become something other than God. 'Allama Tabataba'i, discussing how to judge whether a spiritual teacher is genuine, speaks of what may appear on the road. Reading minds or foretelling the future, he says, "becomes possible at the beginning of spiritual vision", but "the stage of proximity to Allah is far away from this stage", and such things "are not a sign of anybody's being a favorite of Allah"¹². For him the feats are beside the point: something a student should look past when deciding whom to trust. One addresses the heart of the seeker, the other the eye of the one choosing a guide. Neither makes powers the aim of the path.

Seeking, and nothing else

With powers set aside, what remains is the definition Sheikh Bahmanpour gave at the end of his first class. 'Irfan "is actually seeking and nothing else". What it seeks is two things: *ma'rifah*, the knowing of God, and the love of God. These, he says, are the two things by which the friends of God fly: a knowledge that keeps increasing and a love that is never quenched.

⁸Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 4.

¹⁰Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 61.

¹¹Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 44.

¹²Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 101.



ع WORD STUDY: ‘IRFAN AND MA‘RIFAH

‘*Irfan*, *ma‘rifah*, ‘*arif* and its plural ‘*urafa*’ belong to one family of words about knowing. An ‘*arif*, as Sheikh Bahmanpour puts it, is “someone who knows”. “Mystic” is used of Christians, Hindus and Buddhists alike; ‘*arif* is the Islamic word, and it makes a precise claim. Murtada Mutahhari draws the line. The philosopher wants a correct picture of the world in his mind. The ‘*arif* “wishes to reach the very kernel and reality of existence, God, to become connected to it and witness it”¹³. *Lantern of the Path*, attributed to Imam al-Sadiq (‘a), puts it in one line: “There is no way to Allah except via knowledge”¹⁴. What kind of knowledge that is, and how it differs from what we learn from books, is the subject of Chapter 3.

‘Allama Tabataba’i’s definition says the same thing: “The real gnostic is he who worships Allah not, because he hopes for any reward or is afraid of any punishment, but only because he knows Him and loves Him”¹⁵.

Each step of this chapter has led here. The minimum saves, and nothing here disputes it; but the Quran sets its signs in the middle of ordinary life and addresses them to those who reflect, know, listen and reason. Most of us pass them by, not because the signs are faint, but because the faculty that should receive them has rusted. That faculty is part of how we are made, and it can be repaired. The Quran describes people in whom it works, promises them nearness, a good life and freedom from fear and grief, and opens their rank to any believer who obeys and acts righteously. The only aim worthy of that effort is God Himself. ‘Irfan, then, is worth pursuing: it is the training of the soul to perceive and love God, open to every believer, and sought for God alone.

If the aim is to know and love God, what does that longing sound like?

► TRY THIS

Sheikh Bahmanpour built his first lesson on the four signs of Surah al-Rum. For one week, read Q 30:21–24 slowly once a day. After each verse, ask yourself what he found in its ending: whether you reflect, whether you know, whether you listen and whether you use your reason. Then, at some point in the day, no-

¹³Mutahhari, Tabataba’i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 12.

¹⁴*Lantern of the Path* (Misbah al-Shari’a), p. 9.

¹⁵Mutahhari, Tabataba’i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 4.



tice one of the four signs where it actually occurs in your life: the affection in your home, the languages and colours of the people you meet, your own sleep and the work that earns your living, or the rain.